

INDIA, HISTORY OF



THE SUBCONTINENT OF INDIA has been home to some of the world's great civilizations. Dynasties such as the Buddhist Mauryans, the Hindu Guptas, and the Muslim Mughals spread their cultures and religions across India. As a result, India has remained dominated by a host of different cultures, a fact that has made it difficult to unify under one ruler. The Mughal Empire declined in the 18th century, and Britain added India to its empire, imposing strong rule from outside. India became independent in 1947, when the Muslim state of Pakistan was also created.

Buddhist and Hindu empires

In 324 BC, Chandragupta Maurya, king of Magadha, eastern India, began to conquer northern India. He founded the Buddhist Mauryan Empire, the first to unite the subcontinent. His dynasty was followed by the Guptas, a family of Hindu rulers who controlled India from c. AD 320 to c.700.



Nalanda University, founded during the Gupta period

Chola statue of a goddess

Elaborate head-dress shows high status.

Chola metalworkers cast bronze statues decorated with fine details.



Gupta Empire

India flourished under the Guptas. They promoted education, founding some of the earliest universities, and encouraged the arts of architecture, painting, sculpture, dancing, and music. The writers of the period produced books in the Sanskrit language that are still read today.

Imperial Cholas

The Cholas, from southeastern India, were a Hindu people. In the late 9th century, they took over much of southern India and what is now Sri Lanka, ruling the area from the city of Tanjore. A seafaring people, their merchants sailed west to Arabia and east to China, organizing their trade efficiently and introducing India's first money.

Statues such as this were often commissioned from the artists of southern India by Chola merchants, many of whom were very wealthy.



Steatite seal from Indus Valley, 2500–2000 BC

Indus civilization

This culture flourished from c.2500–1600 BC. It was based in large, well-planned cities near the Indus River (in what is now Pakistan). The people grew corn, wove cotton, and wrote a script we are unable to read.

Aryan culture

Around 1600 BC, hordes of nomads moved out of the area between the Black and Caspian Seas. Some of them moved into the area around the Indus. Ancient religious texts called the Vedas describe their life, their gods, and their system of social castes or classes, which later spread to the rest of India.

Statue of Surya, a god of the Aryans

Coming of Islam

Between the 8th and 12th centuries, many Muslim invaders from Arabia and western Asia attacked India. By 1206, a Muslim sultan, based in Delhi, ruled the whole of the northern Indian plain. Under the Delhi sultans and the later Mughal emperors, large areas of India were under Islamic rule. India's Muslim rulers built fine cities, but some were intolerant of other religious faiths.



Tomb of the Muslim emperor, Tughluq Shah, near Delhi.

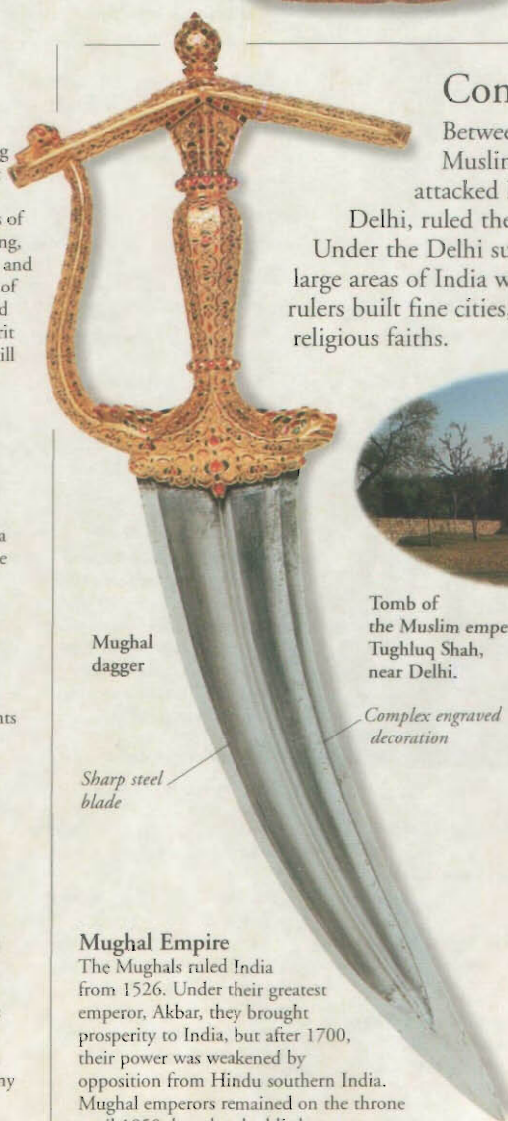
Delhi Sultanate

In the 13th and 14th centuries, the sultans of Delhi ruled much of northern India, from the Punjab in the west to Bihar in the east. But this empire was unstable. The sultans always had to fight opposition from Hindu states in southern India, and from the Mongols, who conquered Delhi in 1398.

Mughal dagger

Sharp steel blade

Complex engraved decoration



Mughal Empire

The Mughals ruled India from 1526. Under their greatest emperor, Akbar, they brought prosperity to India, but after 1700, their power was weakened by opposition from Hindu southern India. Mughal emperors remained on the throne until 1858, but they had little power.

Aurangzeb

The last great Mughal ruler, Aurangzeb (1618–1707), became emperor in 1658. In 1678, there was a Hindu revolt against his rule and Aurangzeb began a series of costly wars against the Hindus. He expanded the empire, but bankrupted it with his wars, and it began to break up on his death.

